

The books call guilt excess baggage. You can continue to haul it around or decide to shed it. The choice is yours, but to retire at 35 you have to shed it. Don't worry; there are enough Jewish mothers, evangelicals, and Woody Allen characters to pick up the slack.

Here are more rules:

Go for responsible pleasure

Modify the work ethic

Live without guilt

Erma Bombeck calls guilt the gift that keeps on giving. My advice is to give it back. Try to live for responsible pleasure rather than out of a sense of guilt. Life is too short to fill it with things other people want us to do.

TOWARD A NEW LIFE

Your own replacement for the work ethic may turn out to be personal growth, spiritual well-being, or inner peace rather than responsible pleasure. Whatever it is, it should be immediate, here and now.

Cook because you enjoy cooking, not because you enjoy eating. Go to Rome to look at churches and ruins, not to take pictures to show the neighbors. Go to Argentina to drink wine and eat steaks, not to be the only one on your block to go to Argentina. Play golf for the fresh air and companionship, not to lower your handicap. Play with your kids to have fun with your kids, not to show them how to behave when they get to be adults.

With this approach you never have to answer the question, "What are you going to do with it?" As in, "Why are you learning to play drums? I mean, what are you going to do with it?" Or in, "Why are you going back to school to study Eastern religions? What are you going to do with it?" Or in, "Why study French cooking? You can't afford the calories. And what are you going to do with it?"